Kurdi

From the complex of Sultan Qalawun (683-84 AH / 1284-85 CE)

74 - W: 25.7 cm; H: 230.8 cm 75 - W: 20.6 cm; H: 166.5 cm

Inv. no. 4144



Traditionally known a rigl al-kurdi ("leg of the kurdi"), these pieces represent the vertical element of the kurdi, typically the decorated underside of a lintel separating two areas, which terminates in a muqarnas stalactite followed by a blind arch. The muqarnas may either be carved from one or more solid blocks of wood or composed of numerous pieces cut at angles to form a stalactite running in the longitudinal direction. Kurdis of this type frequently formed part of iwan arches and gained prominence in Cairene architecture during the late 14th and 15th centuries, continuing into the Ottoman and Khedival periods. The present examples are attributed to Sultan Qalawun's complex on al-Mu'izz St. (683-84 AH / 1284-85

CE) on the basis of their provenance; if correct, this would place them well over a century before the period in which the type is generally thought to have flourished. Their origins consequently remain a matter for further investigation.

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